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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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CHAPTER V c. 1904-1907 A GIRL'S FIRST MARRIAGE ()

Then the bridegroom's special friend comes forward with a horse, all the bridegroom's friends have come to fetch the bride. Slaves used-to carry the bride themselves, they didn't have horses—the groom's chief friend would carry the bride home on his back. *Mawankiya* dresses the bride in a man's trousers and a short petticoat, she wraps her cloth round her on top and puts her kerchief on her head, then she is set on the horse with her younger sister behind her; the groom's friend holds the reins, the girls and young men surround them, and off they go. The girls hold up the bridegroom's friend, they won't let him start off until he has given them some money—three times he has to give them money before they will let him go, with the bride on her horse. Then on the way to the bridegroom's home the girls try to stop his friends from taking away the bride. The drummers and singers lead the procession, the drum-rhythm says:

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*You have had your gifts,
Get to your house,
Go and taste the chickens of your husband's house!*

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All the girls sing:

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*The great hunt was a good hunt,
The great hunt brought meat,
In the great hunt we caught—
(The great hunt was a good hunt)—
We caught, we caught
Ten hares, ten ground-squirrels,
Ten buffaloes, ten gazelles,
Ten elephants, ten antelopes,
And ten hyenas—we caught them.
The great hunt was good .*

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They are singing this when the procession arrives at the bridegroom's compound, then the girls block up the entrance and say they won't let the bridegroom's friends bring the bride in. Then the bridegroom's kinsfolk bring some corn and salt for the horse to eat (if his friend has brought the bride on his back, he pretends to eat [94](#) the corn and spits it out), when he has eaten the horse enters the compound with the bride on his back. The friends and kinsfolk who have brought her all follow her in. The bride is helped to dismount, and taken into her new hut; her kinswomen fill her hut, the bridegroom's kinswomen are inside the compound too, all the men remain without at the front of the house. But when they arrive at her hut door they find her new joking relations, the bridegroom's grandmothers, sitting there and saying that they can't come in with the bride! When they are given a little money they get up and let her in. Then it is the turn of the bride's girl-friends to prevent her from entering her hut, they sing and the chief *kawa* hangs onto the bride.

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